Roger Webb Plays Gershwin (MFP 50099)

This album presents a suite of Gershwin arrangements by the Roger Webb Trio, a UK-based jazz ensemble led by the exceptionally talented pianist, composer, and arranger Roger Webb. I don't think Roger Webb is super well-known, his work in film and television (including the haunting score for Bartleby) is largely overlooked, although very sought-after after by some. Here his arrangements are both casually inventive yet very respectful of the source material. It is, after all, a Music For Pleasure record so it is not way off piste; a pretty jazz outing and a very easy and enjoyable listen.

The album sits intriguingly within the eclectic catalogue of MFP, yet another instance of their scattergun approach to commercial releases. There is no denying the musicianship on these recordings Webb and his trio bring a polished, studio-ready precision, likely honed through their work in stock and production music. The result is a record that, while not groundbreaking, is clearly well-crafted and still enjoyable, appealing to both jazz enthusiasts and casual listeners.

One caveat, however, is the album's cover art, which is, frankly, atrocious. Its garish design and clashing fonts do a disservice to the music within, but don't let that deter you this is, although not a hidden gem, a record that deserves to be judged solely by its auditory merits.